

- Are there any small things that contradict my thoughts, which I might be discounting as not important?
- Five years from now, if I look back at this situation, will I look at it any differently? Will I focus on any different part of my experience?
- Are there any strengths or positives in me or the situation, which I am ignoring?
- Am I jumping to any conclusions which are not completely justified by the evidence?
- Is there any evidence that might lead to a different conclusion than the one I've made?

When examining the evidence that challenges the hot thought it is important to consider the effects of that thought on your life. Is this thought helpful to me? Will thoughts like this help me achieve my goals and a life worth living? Do thoughts like this truly have my best interests at heart?

CREATING ALTERNATIVES OR MORE BALANCED THINKING

In working through columns 5 and 6, the evidence may now suggest that the originally held hot thought may not be entirely true. So now it is important to actually replace the original thought with an alternative thought that is more balanced and reflective of reality. This is done in column 7 of the thought record.

HOT THOUGHT	NEW BALANCED THOUGHT
Nothing ever works out for me.	<i>I have had my share of things not work out, but good things have also happened in my life.</i>
I can't stand it when people don't like me.	<i>Although it would feel better if everyone liked me, I can survive without everyone's approval. It is important that those people I really value, think well of me and help me grow as a person.</i>
I'm a failure.	<i>I have failed at some things I've tried. I have been successful at many others.</i>
You can't trust anyone, they'll just hurt you.	<i>Not everyone can or should be trusted. Trust needs to be earned and I need to give some people a chance.</i>

Can you see how the first column is written in extremes and absolutes? The second column is a more balanced version, with an alternative way of thinking about things. The second approach takes work to create, and a great deal of insight. The change does not happen overnight. The extreme automatic thoughts have taken years to become believable, so it will take time,